

General Knowledge

Ancient History

STUDY NOTES

Indo-Greek Invasion



Indo-Greek Invasion



Early Greek Contact with India

- India's interaction with the Greeks began with the **invasion of north-western India by Alexander (327–325 BC)**, marking the first significant contact between the two cultures.
- After Alexander's death, his general **Seleucus Nicator** established his rule from **Turkey to the Indus River**.
- **Chandragupta Maurya** later defeated Seleucus Nicator, leading to a **marriage alliance** between the two, symbolizing a diplomatic and peaceful resolution.
- **Bindusara**, the son of Chandragupta Maurya, maintained good relations with **Antiochus I** of Syria, strengthening the ties between the Mauryan Empire and the Seleucid Empire.
- **Ashoka's Rock Edict 13** mentions five **Yona/Yavana kings**, indicating the deep and enduring political and cultural ties between India and the Greek rulers.
- It is believed that the **Mauryan Empire's administrative institutions** were influenced by **Persian and Greek systems**, showcasing the impact of Greek governance on Indian political structures.
- Trade between India and the Greek world flourished, with **luxury items** like **ivory, pearls, indigo**, and aromatic substances such as **spikenard** and **malabathrum** being exported from India.

- These interactions with the Greeks not only influenced **trade and economy** but also contributed to **cultural exchanges** between the two great civilizations.

Indo-Greek Invasion

- The **Indo-Greek Kingdom**, also referred to as **Indo-Bactrians** or **Yavana Kingdom** ruled over the **Northwestern part of the Indian Subcontinent**, including **Afghanistan, Pakistan, and parts of Iran**.
- It started with the invasion by **Demetrius I** around **180 BCE**, following the decline of the **Mauryan Empire**.



Causes of Indo-Greek Invasion

- **Weakening of the Seleucid Empire:**
 - After **250 BCE**, the **Seleucid Empire** weakened and began to disintegrate.
 - The Seleucid Emperor **Antiochus III** conquered **Kabul** and laid the foundation for the Greek invasion of India.
- **Bactrian Invasion:**
 - **Bactria** and **Parthia** gained independence from the Syrian Empire during the **3rd century BCE**.
 - **Scythian tribes**, displaced by the construction of the **Great Wall of China**, pushed towards Greek and Parthian territories.
 - This displacement encouraged the **Bactrian Greeks** to invade **India**.
- **Demetrius I:**
 - Son of **Euthydemus**, a Greco-Bactrian king.
 - **Demetrius I** invaded **Afghanistan**, and **Punjab**, and extended his rule across Northwestern India.

Rulers of the Indo-Greek Kingdom

Ruler	Important Contributions & Events
Demetrius II (180 BCE)	● First known Indo-Greek king. ● Conflict with Pushyamitra Shunga. ● Extended Bactrian rule south of the Hindu Kush. ● Issued bilingual square coins (Greek and Kharosthi).
Menander I (165/145 – 130 BCE)	● Most important Indo-Greek ruler. ● Ruled from Kabul Valley to Western Uttar Pradesh. ● Described as Soter or "Savior". ● Converted to Buddhism under Nagasena. ● The Buddhist text Milinda Panho is a dialogue between Menander and Nagasena. ● Had his capital at Sakala (modern Sialkot, Pakistan). ● Led a successful expedition to Mathura and attacked Pataliputra.

	Famous for his coinage (with Greek gods and Buddhist symbols).
Antialcidas	- His emissary, Heliodorus, was sent to the court of Bhagabhadra. - Erected a Garuda-Dhvaja pillar in Vidisha (dedicated to Lord Vishnu). - Adopted Vaishnavism.

Menander I - The Most Notable Indo-Greek Ruler

- Reign and Conquests:**
 - Menander I** ruled over **Punjab** and expanded the Indo-Greek Empire to the **Swat Valley** and **Kabul River Valley**.
 - He led successful military campaigns in **Mathura** and reached **Patliputra**, although he did not consolidate control over these areas.
- Conversion to Buddhism:**
 - Under the influence of **Buddhist sage Nagasena**, Menander converted to **Buddhism**.
 - The **Milinda Panho** (Questions of Milinda) records the discussions between **Menander** and **Nagasena**.
- Significance of Coinage:**
 - Menander issued a vast number of coins, which featured **Greek deities** and **Buddhist symbols** like the **Lotus** and **Wheel**.
 - His coinage covers the **largest geographical area** compared to other Indo-Greek rulers.

Art, Ideology, and Religion During Indo-Greek Rule

- Artistic Influence:**
 - Indo-Greek art showcased **Hellenistic** and **Indian cultural fusion**, which can be seen in the remains of cities like **Sakala**, **Ai-Khanoum**, and **Taxila**.
- Coins:**

- **Bilingual coins** (Greek and Kharosthi scripts) depicted Greek deities such as **Athena**, **Apollo**, and **Zeus** along with Indian religious symbols like **Dharmachakra** and **animals** like the **bull** and **elephant**.
- **Indo-Greeks** were the **first to issue gold coins** in India.
- **Influence on Religion:**
 - Indo-Greeks played a significant role in promoting **Buddhism**.
 - Their rule helped in the development of **Mahayana Buddhism** and **Bhakti traditions**.
 - The fusion of **Greek and Indian artistic styles** led to the development of the **Gandhara School of Art**, which depicted Buddha in the **Graeco-Roman style**.
- **Cultural Contributions:**
 - **Heliodorus**, the Greek ambassador, adopted **Vaishnavism** and dedicated a **pillar to Vishnu** in Vidisha, marking one of the earliest instances of **Vaishnavism** in Indian epigraphy.
 - Indo-Greek rulers like **Menander I** contributed to **architectural development** and administrative governance.



Trade and Economy During Indo-Greek Rule

- **Strategic Trade Position:**
 - The Indo-Greek territories, particularly **Bactria**, controlled trade routes between **Gandhara** and the **West**.

- Greek merchants became affluent, and **Tamil literature** mentions **Greek ships** bringing merchandise.
- **Introduction of Gold Coins:**
 - Indo-Greeks were the **first rulers to introduce gold coins** in India, used for larger transactions.
 - Their coinage was **bilingual**, facilitating trade and cultural exchange between **India** and **Greece**.
- **Impact on Religion:**
 - The **Indo-Greeks** contributed to the **spread of Buddhism** through **patronage** and **interactions** with local religious leaders.
 - **Mahayana Buddhism** and **Hinduism** were influenced by **Greek artistic styles** and religious practices.

Key Contributions of Indo-Greek Rule

- **Cultural Exchange:** The Indo-Greek period was a time of **cultural amalgamation** between **Greek and Indian traditions**, particularly in **art, coinage, and religious thought**.
- **Religious Influence:** Their rule contributed significantly to the **spread of Buddhism**, influencing **Mahayana** doctrines.
- **Art and Architecture:** Indo-Greeks left behind a rich legacy of **coinage, sculpture, and architecture**, particularly in the **Gandhara School of Art**.

Decline of Indo-Greek Rule

- The Indo-Greek Empire greatly diminished after **Menander I's death** in **130 BCE** due to new emerging powers.
- The **Scythians**, pushed by **Yuezhi**, started invading **Bactria** and Indo-Greek territories by the **mid-2nd century BCE**.
- **Internal Conflicts and Economic Strain:**
 - Internal power struggles and external attacks weakened the Indo-Greek Kingdom.
 - The decline of trade routes further strained their economy.
- **End of Indo-Greek Rule:**

- The last Indo-Greek ruler, **Strato II**, ruled until **55 BCE** (or 10 AD according to some sources).
- Eventually, **Kushanas** and other neighbouring powers overtook Indo-Greek territories.